CONCLUSION

The 2015 general election fulfilled the high hopes of people of Myanmar to vote freely and fairly, avoiding pre- and post-election instability. It was successful due to the cooperative efforts of the UEC, government, military, CSOs, media, and international observers. The UEC as an integral institution proved up to the task, despite skepticism about its role. International agencies, as important supporters of democratic development, also made major contributions. Overall, the UEC has proven to be a welcome development, as many reforms have taken place that put it in a much more favourable light at the end of 2015 than only a few years before. The willingness of the UEC to work with international and local observer missions is a significant feature of its changed circumstances.

The military went along with the 2015 election and did not obstruct or play a spoiling role, despite ample opportunities should it have wished to do so. It stayed neutral, as it did in the 2012 by-election. Reducing the Tatmadaw's involvement in politics remains a matter to be dealt with through consideration of history, and building of trust. Significant challenges lie ahead and it is by no means certain that Myanmar's political transition will go smoothly, but the 2015 election marks an historic achievement on the path to a democratic Myanmar, one for which all institutions involved deserve credit, as well as the politically active and discerning Myanmar public.

Appendix

Election commission members, 1960 election

1. Thadoe Thudama U Tin
2. Thadoe Mahar Thayey Sithu U Chan Tun Aung
3. Wanna Kyaw Htin U Ohn Pe

Election commission members, 1990 election

1. U Ba Htay
2. U Saw Kyar Doe
3. U San Maung
4. Saya Chae
5. U Kyaw Nyunt
6. U Aye Maung